

Assessment of PhD in Technology and Humanities, AY2025-26

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I. Introduction

The PhD degree in Technology and Humanities (PHD-THUM) is the only doctoral degree program offered by the Humanities, Arts, and Social Sciences department. It was established in the 1990s as a PhD degree in Technical Communication, and the focus was expanded to other fields in the humanities in the early 2000s. There are currently 7 active students in the program. The current assessment is based on an analysis of a sample of thesis, papers, and qualifying examinations submitted by these students in the last 5 years.

II. Process

The assessment was based on the three learning outcomes on knowledge, communication, and professional standards and practices as outlined below

	Learning Outcomes
1	Students will demonstrate knowledge of research methods and literature in the field.
2	Derive and communicate meaning from the expressions and artifacts of human experience by identifying the key features of a text, corpus, or cultural artifact, placing those features into a historical context, and articulating their own insights or analysis.
3	Demonstrate working knowledge of professional standards and practices within their field and the ability to complete professional-level projects.

Table 1: Learning Outcomes

Selection Criteria

The assessment committee collected nine (9) artifacts comprised of research papers and comprehensive examinations from current PhD students. This provided a cross section of student activity during their program of study (rather than a dissertation or thesis, which is a summative

representation of their activities in the program). For this round of assessment, the committee was interested in assessing learning goals and outcomes in a student's process of study. Data will be used to discuss courses and exams. Future assessment will then switch to thesis artifacts, which will enable us to analyze the ability of students to integrated iterative learning in their own research practice.

All documents were anonymized for the purpose of this assessment.

Rater Training and Norming

There were six reviewers: Clarissa Busch (Ethics), Jennifer deWinter (Communication), Saran Ghatak (Social Science), Elisabeth Hildt (Ethics), Carly Kocurek (History), and Kathryn Petrozzo (Ethics). Reviewers first discussed the process and the document selection and process. With so few documents, the committee opted not to do formal norming on 3 sample documents. Rather, the committee discussed the outcomes and agreed on what the specific outcomes were.

The rubric for assessment was a 6-point scale, which compelled reviewers to determine high-low assessments within poor/average/excellent categories.

The committee used inter-rater reliability methods. Each document received 2 readers, who read the document in isolation. At the end of scoring, the artifact scores were compared. If the awarded points were within 1 point of each other, then the reviews were considered normed and in agreement. If there was a 2 point or greater difference between the scores, then the paper went to a third reader for assessment. If the score assigned by the reviewers fell within one point of one another, there was no need for an artifact to be reviewed by a third reviewer.

After the numerical assessments were concluded, the committee discussed the results and what they observed, which informed the discussion below.

The following scoring scheme was used:

LEARNING OUTCOME	ASSESSED VALUE		
Students will demonstrate knowledge of research methods and literature in the field.	Poor 1 - 2	Average 3 - 4	Excellent 5 - 6
Derive and communicate meaning from the expressions and artifacts of human experience by identifying the key features of a text, corpus, or cultural artifact, placing those features into a historical context, and articulating their own insights or analysis.	Poor 1 - 2	Average 3 - 4	Excellent 5 - 6

Demonstrate working knowledge of professional standards and practices within their field and the ability to complete professional-level projects.	Poor 1 - 2	Average 3 - 4	Excellent 5 - 6
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Table 2: AY Learning Objective Assessment Scale

IV. Results

Learning Outcome	Assessed Value
1. Students will demonstrate knowledge of research methods and literature in the field.	<i>Mean Score:</i> 4.5 <i>StdDev:</i> 0.89
2. Derive and communicate meaning from the expressions and artifacts of human experience by identifying the key features of a text, corpus, or cultural artifact, placing those features into a historical context, and articulating their own insights or analysis.	<i>Mean Score:</i> 4.31 <i>StdDev:</i> 0.83
3. Demonstrate working knowledge of professional standards and practices within their field and the ability to complete professional-level projects	<i>Mean Score:</i> 4:37 <i>StdDev:</i> 0.83

Table 3: Results

The results show that student artifacts in process tend toward the high level of average, and with standard deviation in consideration, many of the outcomes were achieved within average to low excellent range.

V. Discussion

The above results demonstrate that while the program is successful in meeting the learning objectives, there is room for improvement.

Overall, the papers demonstrated competence in research and presentation of arguments. They all had clearly articulated arguments and organized primary and secondary sources within the paper to support the arguments. The committee did discuss that it might have been useful to have the assignment sheet to see if the argument was given to the student or if they had to go through a process of formal invention to articulate an argument.

All papers did include external sources to back their claims. However, this is where the committee spent most of the time of the discussion. The committee noted that, in cases with primary source material, students were not yet expert in weaving together secondary source material to provide theoretical frames nor interpretive context within the presented paragraphs. Further, their research did not think broadly about a topic and what disciplinary/contextual knowledge might be relevant to their topics. Finally, while the papers deftly discussed their external sources, most students over relied on a limited number of external sources—something that we would expect a graduate student to move beyond.

Additionally, sections on research needed more clarity in articulating the project and the methodology of inquiry. We know from pedagogical research that methodology is one of the hardest things for graduate students in humanities and social sciences to formally articulate, so this was not surprising to the committee. However, the committee did note that selection criteria for primary and secondary sources were unclear. Further, analysis framing was not articulated well. This is not to say that there was not a sense of method. However, many of the documents fell short of the professional practices of the field.

VI. Future Directions

Humanistic inquiry needs multi-perspectival approaches of scholarly inquiry. Based on the findings, the committee will return to the department to discuss the following areas of improvement:

A stronger emphasis on research skills: The department already offers the research methods course on a regular rotation. A larger discussion needs to occur about what are the specific approaches to research that we are engaging in (especially important now that we are a new department with more disciplines represented), and how those approaches have multiple touchpoints in the curriculum.

We would also like to think as a department about how to scaffold a student's experience in considering alternative explanations in forming research questions. A stronger emphasis on comparing competing perspectives in explaining the evidence would be encouraged.

Already, the department offers an academic writing course. The question that the department now needs to consider is whether that should be a stand-alone class or modules for other classes to use.

It might behoove faculty to consider these questions in light of their experiences advising theses and dissertations. These are the courses that provide the foundational skills for independent research later on, and based on faculty advising experiences and this data, how might we consider the course work and student activities to ensure high-quality success.

Ultimately, we were pleased to see how well students were performing based on this sample.